

A New Beginning: Our Journey from Afghanistan to Canada

Leaving Home

Life in Afghanistan was all I had ever known. The streets, the people, the food—it was home. My family lived in a small but happy house, surrounded by relatives and friends. Life was simple, but it was not always safe. My father had worked with the Canadian forces, trying to bring peace to our country. Because of this, our lives were at risk.

Then, everything changed. The government of Afghanistan fell. Chaos spread across the country. People were desperate to leave, fearing what would come next. My father knew it was no longer safe for us to stay. We had to go.

At first, we didn't know where we would end up. The journey ahead was uncertain, but one thing was clear—we could no longer stay in the place we had always called home. The decision was not easy. We were leaving behind everything—our home, our relatives, our culture, and the only life we had ever known. But we had no choice. Safety had to come first.

Waiting in Pakistan

Like many Afghan immigrants, we had to go to Pakistan to wait for approval to move to Canada. We spent around 11 months there, living in uncertainty. At first, it felt like a temporary stay, but as the months passed, the waiting became difficult.

Pakistan was different from Afghanistan, but it was not home. We were in a country that was not ours, waiting for news that would determine our future. Every day, we hoped for an update—some sign that our journey forward would begin.

Life in Pakistan was not easy. We had left behind everything we knew, and now we were in a place where we had no real stability. What made it even harder was that the people and government of Pakistan were not welcoming to Afghans. Instead of treating us as refugees in need, we were often treated as outsiders who didn't belong.

The police were especially difficult. They would charge Afghans unnecessarily for things we didn't even do. Sometimes, they would stop people on the streets and demand money for no reason. We always had to be careful and avoid any trouble, even when we had done nothing wrong. The feeling of being unwanted made our time in Pakistan even more stressful.

Finally, after nearly a year of waiting, the news came—we had been accepted to move to Canada. A mix of emotions filled our hearts. We were relieved and happy, but also nervous. Canada was far away, and we didn't know what to expect. Still, we knew this was our chance at a better future.

The Journey

Leaving Pakistan and boarding the plane to Canada felt unreal. We had spent so long waiting, and now, our journey was truly beginning. The flight was long, and as we lifted off, I looked out the window. I thought about Afghanistan, about the streets I used to walk, the home we had left behind, and the life we once had. Now, we were heading toward the unknown.

When we landed in Canada, everything felt different. The cold air hit us immediately. Back home, the weather was warm, but here, the cold made our breath visible. The roads were wider, the buildings taller, and the people more diverse. It was overwhelming, but at the same time, it felt like a fresh start.

A New World

At first, adjusting to life in Canada was difficult. We didn't know anyone. We didn't know where to go or how things worked.

Simple things like buying groceries or using public transport felt confusing. But one thing was clear—people were kind. Strangers smiled at us. Store workers helped us find things. Teachers checked on me at school. It was small gestures like these that made us feel welcome.

School was the biggest challenge for me. In Afghanistan, school hours were shorter, and the system was different. Here, everything was longer, and the subjects felt harder. But with time, I started to adjust. I made a few friends, especially with other immigrants who understood what it was like to be new.

Holding On to Our Culture

Even though we were now in Canada, we never forgot where we came from. At home, we spoke our native language. My mother still cooked the same Afghan dishes, filling our house with the familiar smells of home. Whenever there was an Afghan festival or event, we made sure to attend.

At the same time, we embraced Canadian culture. We celebrated Canada Day and learned about the country's history. I started playing cricket with a group of Afghan friends, but I also learned about Canada's national sport, hockey. It was a mix of old and new, of holding onto our roots while growing into our new life.

A Safe and Bright Future

The biggest change after moving to Canada was the sense of safety. In Afghanistan, we always had to be careful. In Pakistan, we had to deal with unfair treatment. But here, we could walk outside without fear. We could go to school without worrying about violence. Life felt peaceful.

I now have dreams that once seemed impossible. Back in Afghanistan, opportunities were limited. Here, I have the chance to pursue what I love. I dream of playing cricket for Canada one day. I want to make my family proud and give back to the country that gave us a second chance.

Looking back, the journey was not easy. We left behind so much. We spent almost a year in Pakistan, not knowing what would happen next, dealing with mistreatment and uncertainty. But we also gained a new home, a place where we could be safe and free. Canada opened its doors to us, and we stepped into a new beginning. And for that, we will always be grateful.